DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Is the Whole Book About?

Daat Tevunot, Summary of the Whole Book

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** Summary of the whole book (§1-195), siyum, and choosing the next book **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 8 January 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Why go over it all again

After a longer break than expected, the Rabbi explained why he always reviews at the end. "You can only fully understand something once you finish it." Ideally the group would start again from the beginning; that, he said, they could do in their own time. Instead he gave a quick summary of all ten sections, using the English edition's summary on page 653, then a siyum, reflections from the group, and a discussion of the next book.

The learning that evening, and for the coming year, was dedicated to the memory of Moshe Ezra, who had been an integral part of the group from the very beginning, attending almost every shiur since they started Derech Hashem about four years earlier.

Section 1: the purpose of creation

The student begins troubled: the world does not seem fair. The fundamental principle, which we learned already in Derech Hashem, is that God created the world to bestow goodness, and He does so by giving human beings the ability to perfect themselves.

Animals cannot choose between good and bad, and neither can angels. Only human beings can. When we choose good, we make ourselves the best human beings we can be. "We are the artists of our future," said the Rabbi, and not only in this world but for eternity. The height of goodness is God Himself, so the greatest good is to be close to Him. God could simply have made us close, but then our goodness would not be our own. It has to be intrinsic, and we earn it by choosing.

Section 2: God's unity

The whole book, and in truth all the Ramhal's works, rest on the Yihud Hashem. The purpose of creation is to bestow good; the means is that God conceals His oneness and then reveals it, at the end of days or through us in our lifetimes.

The Rabbi asked the group to define Yihud Hashem "after two years". Not only that there is one God, but that there is no other force: nothing can happen without God willing it. For human beings to reveal that, it must first be concealed, so God creates a world in which it

appears there is more than one force. Concealment creates evil, and by overcoming evil we show it is nothing.

Adam could have done this himself. The whole test of the tree of knowledge, and of all the misvot and all of life, is this: do you ascribe independent power and reality to anything outside God? By eating, Adam and Havah showed that they believed the tree, as the serpent promised, had power of its own. So humanity has to go through the whole process again.

Section 3: concealment

Concealment lasts at most six thousand years. Afterwards there are stages of revelation, from six to seven thousand, seven to eight, and so on, but the complete concealment is in this period, so that humans can reveal God's oneness by choosing good. If God's unity were clear to everyone, no one could do bad, because one only does bad thinking one can gain by it.

But even now, in the background, there is the constant force guiding everything to its perfection. The Rabbi has always called it "the override button"; the Ramhal calls it the tikkun haklali.

Section 4: body and soul

To choose, we need both: a body pulling down and a soul pulling up. The body represents concealment, the soul the Yihud. When we do good we reveal the Neshamah; when we do bad, we increase concealment in the universe.

The body is made of parts, while the Yihud is one. To the old question that the soul too has five levels, the Rabbi said he still has no full answer, but the soul is certainly more unified than the body; once you reach the fifth level, "you've got everything all in one".

Then the stages. Until six thousand years the body is in control and the soul must overpower it. From six to seven, the body is still in control but "on mute", like Moshe on the mountain for forty days. From seven, the soul is in control and the body subordinate, increasingly so until ten thousand. Any eating in the world to come is not eating as we know it, not even like Adam's before the sin, because the body has no desire of its own.

Section 5: what is evil?

How can a wholly good God create evil? Everything is created by emanations. God sends an emanation that would give good, then holds it back, like dimming a light, and the damaged arrangement allows evil to exist. Everything is interconnected, like cogs. The Rabbi recalled the saying attributed to Rabbi Yisrael Salanter, that when a yeshiva student does not learn as he should, it causes someone in Paris to sin.

Yet bad has a silver lining. From darkness we recognise the Yihud Hashem; overcoming tests makes us better; and evil gives us the task of perfecting the world as God's partners.

Section 6: Adam before and after the sin

There are three levels. Level three is ours, after the sin, and each of us decides how high to climb within it. Level two is Adam before the sin, which no one in this world can reach; it takes

death to get there. Level one is where Adam would have reached had he withstood the test: complete revelation, the soul in control. After death we move from level two towards level one according to our deeds.

Destruction comes from lack of unity. That is why on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur we pray that all humanity "will form one band", uniting to recognise the Yihud Hashem. And nothing is ever totally destroyed: the Gemara speaks of the luz bone, and whatever the science, the idea is that a trace always remains from which good is rebuilt. Evil is only ever a means to betterment.

Section 7: hanhagat hamishpat

The main system of this world is hanhagat hamishpat: God responds to what we do. Even a bad response is good, because the worst state is no response at all. "We think of a judge as being bad. But a judge is good." Without judges, criminals would get away with everything.

Judgment comes from love, as a father chastises his child, and it can be sweetened (hamtakat hadinim). There are really three states: judgment; no judgment because God has given up on the world, the worst; and no judgment because Hashem is running everything with love, which is what we ask for on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur.

The group recalled the five levels of revelation, from highest to lowest: the end of days; Har Sinai; the times of miracles and the Temple; our time, without miracles but with the Torah; and the first two thousand years before Avraham, with neither.

Section 8: the force that receives

Man has a dual nature: the most elevated creature when he perfects himself, and the most prone to evil. When the righteous use free choice for God, they become His partners and come face to face with Him, as Moshe did, with no barriers. When we perfect the world, we as a nation and as individuals receive the flow, and more blessing comes into the world. That is the meaning of Shekhinah: not that God is here and not there, but that there is more flow, a dwelling place where He can dwell.

Section 9: the hidden mode and mazal

This is the "override button", where evil is finally destroyed and only good revealed. But for that, the more evil there is, the more the Yihud is revealed in the end: the deeper the darkness, the greater the light. The Rabbi warned how dangerous this idea is. Shabtai Sevi's followers abused it to justify terrible debauchery, claiming the darkness had to be complete before the redemption.

In this time, deeds go unnoticed. One would expect all the righteous to suffer and all the wicked to prosper. But the light also comes through the righteous prospering, as channels of blessing. Which saddik serves which way is mazal: not the astrological flow, over which "ein mazal leYisrael", but luck in the sense of a decree. And this is coupled with ordinary reward and punishment, so we can never know. A participant concluded that a suffering person can only keep doing what is right: perhaps it is punishment, perhaps it is his role in bringing light. "You can never outguess it."

Section 10: time, prophecy, creation

Section 10 gathers separate topics. Time is not a closed circle but a spiral staircase rising upwards, with special emanations on Shabbat and Yom Tov. Prophecy is knowledge from God about His attributes, which is always clear, or about future actions, which may come as riddles needing interpretation. Even Moshe saw through a mirror, but a clear one; others saw through unclear and multiple mirrors. Prophecy fluctuates; there was a "prophecy school" for rising higher. Finally, how God creates the finite from the infinite: the Ramhal gives no real answer, only the chain of emanations, descending until finite matter emerges.

The Rabbi read the closing paragraph, §195: the soul is "very happy with its portion", settled in complete faith, and the Ramhal completed the book in Adar Sheni 5494, "almost 300 years ago".

The siyum and reflections

After berakhot over the food, the Rabbi said how much he loved teaching the book. He had learned Derech Hashem and Daat Tevunot in yeshiva because he always had questions, and his teachers recommended them. The beauty of the Ramhal is "his clarity of thought coupled with his mysticism": very like the Rambam, but with a spiritual component the Rambam does not always show.

He asked each participant for their takeaway.

- One had set himself five minutes to summarise the book: the purpose, earning goodness, evil as concealment of the emanation, the revelation of the Yihud, the six thousand years and beyond, judgment that can be overridden, and the interacting cogs, which make it impossible for anyone but Hashem to know the full effect of an action. The Rabbi said it was perfect, except for Adam and the body and soul.
- Asked where the stages up to ten thousand years come from, the Rabbi said the Ramhal draws on the Zohar but condenses it. And even in olam haba the saddikim keep rising "from strength to strength".
- What is the end of the tenth millennium: does everything merge into God? No, said the Rabbi. Not everyone will reach the same level. Using his image of a stadium, nearly everyone gets a ticket, but where you sit, and how intensely you perceive, depends on how hard you worked, for eternity.
- Where does Mashiah fit? People make much of Mashiah, but it matters mainly for what comes after. As the Rambam writes, the world will run as usual, except that Israel will be sovereign and recognised, and choices will be between good and better rather than good and bad. There will still be death, illness and choice until one dies. With about 216 years left until six thousand, Mashiah would bring a Beit HaMikdash and greater closeness, but the main thing is the end of days and tehiyat hametim.
- What of non-Jews? They do not have the task of revealing the Yihud Hashem, but they have the task of living moral lives through the seven laws, the chief of which forbids idolatry, including its subtle form, denying the Yihud. They too will have a place in the stadium. According to the Ramhal a Jew would still have a closer seat for the same deeds; according to the Rambam there is no intrinsic difference, only more opportunities through more misvot.

- Another participant said the book teaches how to become a better person and achieve closeness to God, but was surprised it never mentions the 613 misvot. The Rabbi said that is the point: the misvot are the manifestation of these principles, the blueprint for what "good" means. People who do misvot without understanding this are "doing religious things", not necessarily religious in their mindset. "If you fully were religious in your mindset and you understood this book, you wouldn't behave the way some religious people behave."

What to learn next

There would be no shiur the following week, the shloshim of Moshe Ezra. The Rabbi offered ten options, nine his and one from a participant:

1. **Daat Tevunot, part 2.** A short dialogue focused only on free will. No English translation; about three months.
2. **The Kuzari** by Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi, "one of the first real Zionists": a dialogue between the king of the Khazars and a rabbi, more mystical and emotional than the Rambam or the Ramhal. In English; about a year and a half.
3. **Sefer HaIkkarim** by Rabbi Yosef Albo of Spain: very rational, on the fundamentals of Judaism, based on the Rambam but unafraid to argue with him, famously holding there are three principles of faith rather than thirteen. In English; two years or more.
4. **Moreh Nevuchim** of the Rambam: deeply philosophical, only if everyone commits to come every week and revise. A challenge for the Rabbi too, and a few years' commitment.
5. **Emunot VeDeot** by Rav Saadiah Gaon: the first book to set out Jewish philosophy in an organised way, partly in response to Islam. In English.
6. **Mesillat Yesharim** by the Ramhal: musar rather than philosophy, usually learned before Derech Hashem and Daat Tevunot. "It will definitely make us behave better."
7. **Hovot HaLevavot** by Rabbeinu Bahya ibn Pakuda: ten gates, the first philosophical, the rest ethical, including trust in Hashem. "I really like it."
8. **Mikhtav MeEliyahu** by Rav Eliyahu Dessler: contemporary essays between musar and philosophy, fairly light, with an English version.
9. **Beer HaGolah** by the Maharal of Prague, defending the statements of Hazal at a time when they were ridiculed.
10. **The Rambam's Shemonah Perakim** (a participant's suggestion), his introduction to Avot on human nature: short, four to five months.

Preferences were split between the Kuzari, Mesillat Yesharim and Hovot HaLevavot, with interest also in the Shemonah Perakim. The Rabbi said that for himself he would choose Moreh Nevuchim, and that the most benefit from a teacher would come with the more philosophical books. With Mesillat Yesharim or Hovot HaLevavot he worried he would feel redundant, since they can be read in English alone. He also wanted a book that would attract five or six more people to the table, and suspected the Kuzari would be that magnet: it is well known and a little mystical. He asked everyone to read about the shortlist and send their preference by Friday, so a poster could be made.

Summary

- The purpose of creation is to bestow good, earned through our own choices; the means is the concealment and revelation of the Yihud Hashem: there is no force but God.
- Concealment for up to six thousand years allows evil and choice; body and soul mirror concealment and revelation, and their balance shifts over the millennia.
- Evil is a holding back of God's emanation; judgment is good, the worst state is no response; the hidden tikkun haklali and mazal work behind reward and punishment, so we can never outguess why things happen.
- Section 10 adds time, prophecy as seeing through a mirror, and the unanswerable question of the finite from the infinite.
- At the siyum the Rabbi praised the Ramhal's "clarity of thought coupled with his mysticism", and the group began choosing its next book, with the Kuzari favoured to draw in more learners.

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